take casualties. Finally, at 10 a.m. on 19 November, Lieutenant Colonel Nanda along with five officers, three JCOs and ninety other ranks were killed while trying to clear yet another ambush in the vicinity of Bridge 2. In all, 4 Sikh LI had lost 155 men. After the final battle, the battalion disintegrated into small parties of survivors that then had to dodge their way past Chinese ambush parties as they made their way into Bhutan.

Standing amidst the smoking ruins of his brigade, a large number of his men dead all around him, Hoshiar Singh felt a wave of helplessness. Fate had dealt a cruel hand to this gallant officer. The brigade commander may have been tactically unsuited for the job, but he had the one quality that the other senior commanders all around him lacked—the will to stand and fight. So determined had he been to fight it out at Se-la, he had given no thought to any form of withdrawal. From the moment Anant Pathania refused to let him reinforce 4 Garhwal's success at Nuranang and instead ordered the battalion to pull back, GOC 4 Division had given the Chinese the opening they needed to annihilate his troops. Even now Hoshiar Singh doggedly decided to stay on course for Dirang Dzong, believing he had been ordered to fall back and defend the division locality. After leaving the ambush site, Hoshiar Singh had Lieutenant Colonels Mehta of 1 Sikh and Budhwar of 6 Field Regiment, his GSO–3 and 150 men with him.

The brigade commander and his party continued to push on towards Dirang Dzong for the next forty-eight hours. However, it soon became obvious that the place was crawling with Chinese troops and there was no organized resistance being put up by the remainder of the division's troops. Finally, on 20 November, the decision to head for Dirang Dzong was abandoned and it was decided to turn back and through Manda-la try and head for Bomdila instead. However, this idea was soon discarded as a few local Monpas informed the brigade party that Bomdila too had been abandoned.

By the afternoon of 23 November, the brigade commander's party had been wandering around without any food for more than a week. Having bypassed Phudung, the party was resting in a bamboo jungle near the Phutang Bridge, southwest of Bomdila. Chinese troops belonging to the No. 2 Company of 154 Regiment (419 Unit) had been mercilessly hunting down and gunning Indian stragglers in the region (according to Chinese records, in a total of thirty encounters with Indian troops, they killed 434 and captured 618 Indian soldiers). Earlier in the day they had chanced upon a